Leadership Supervision and Programme Management learner guide

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Lead and support teams, use reflective supervision, and manage community programmes with accountable governance within a professional role.

Use the laws, professional scope, organisational policies and approved referral routes that apply to your setting. This course is educational and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical or legal procedures. All worked cases are fictional. Research notes distinguish published findings from SWEEP teaching examples.

How to use this guide

Read each lesson, explain the worked example in your own words and complete its activity before checking the feedback. The decision points cover the concepts assessed; they are not a substitute for the explanations. Use the separate worksheet to integrate the three lessons. Study time depends on discussion and local adaptation, not a guaranteed completion duration.

Practice case

A community programme is expanding its outreach sessions. Two teams share staff, a manager has a personal connection to a potential supplier, and delayed referrals are adding pressure. The board wants more sessions, while workers report that preparation and follow-up time are insufficient.

Module 1 Leadership governance and role clarity

Clarify decision authority, conflicts of interest and accountability in programme teams.

Clarify authority before acting

Delegation should explain which decisions a worker can make, the limits, the available support and when to seek approval. Being responsible for a programme does not confer every specialist competence. Distinguish routine coordination from decisions reserved for a qualified practitioner, budget holder or governing body. Record authority alongside the reasons for a decision so another person can understand how it was made.

Invite relevant perspectives before the choice is settled. Record significant disagreement and how it was considered; uniform-looking minutes are not proof of inclusion. A personal or financial interest can compromise trust even if the person believes they can remain impartial. Disclose the interest and follow the organisation's independent decision process. Do not quietly resolve the issue by giving yourself permission or asking only people who benefit from the proposal.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: the manager declares the supplier connection before procurement decisions. An authorised independent person handles the selection under policy. The record identifies the decision owner, criteria, reasons and review point rather than simply stating that the team agreed.

Decision points

Delegation should state the decision scope, constraints, support and escalation route; it is not unlimited transfer of responsibility.

When personal interests could influence a decision, disclose the conflict and use the organisation's independent decision process.

Record the decision, its reasons, authority, owner and review point; minutes that only say 'agreed' do not establish accountability.

Invite relevant perspectives before decisions and explain how disagreement was handled; inclusion is more than unanimous-looking minutes.

Authority to manage a programme does not automatically confer competence or permission to perform specialist professional tasks.

Apply the lesson

Write a short delegation note for the outreach coordinator. Include one permitted decision, one limit, a support contact and an escalation route.

Check your reasoning

Authority is explicit and bounded. The response separates management authority from specialist competence and describes a transparent conflict-of-interest process.

Module 2 Reflective supervision and team support

Use structured supervision to support learning, wellbeing and safe escalation.

Use supervision for reflection and safe action

A supervision agreement should make purpose, roles, frequency, records and confidentiality limits clear. Use it to distinguish administrative oversight, learning and support. Reflective discussion starts with a specific situation: what happened, what was observed, what was assumed and how emotions affected the response. Explore alternatives and agree a learning action with a review point. Reflection is not a substitute for immediate safeguarding or incident action.

Give feedback about observable behaviour and its effect, then invite the worker's account before deciding an improvement. Avoid treating all difficulties as personal resilience failures. Repeated overload can reflect workload allocation, task design, staffing or unclear priorities. Review these conditions within managerial authority and escalate what cannot safely be resolved. Supervision supports professional work; it does not authorise practice outside competence or replace specialist care.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: a worker misses follow-up tasks after extra sessions are added. The supervisor reviews the actual demands, hears the worker's account and agrees a manageable priority plan. The manager reviews capacity rather than only recommending a wellbeing exercise.

Decision points

A supervision agreement should clarify purpose, roles, regularity, records, confidentiality limits and routes for urgent concerns.

Reflective supervision explores observations, assumptions, emotions and alternatives, then agrees a learning action; it is more than checking task counts.

Supportive supervision does not replace urgent safeguarding or incident procedures; use the appropriate route without waiting for a scheduled session.

Feedback should identify specific behaviour and its effect, invite the worker's perspective, and agree a feasible improvement and review.

Repeated overload is a work-design issue to review as well as an individual support concern; consider case demands, resources and safe priorities.

Apply the lesson

Prepare a supervision agenda for the outreach case with a reflection question, a specific feedback observation, an agreed action and an urgent-issue route.

Check your reasoning

The agenda balances learning and support with accountability, tests assumptions, addresses work design and does not postpone urgent concerns until the next meeting.

Module 3 Programme management and learning

Use delivery information to manage risks, resources and authorised programme adjustments.

Manage delivery and learn from variation

Compare the intended plan with actual delivery before deciding why a difference occurred. A missed target may involve access barriers, unavailable staff or an unrealistic assumption; the count alone cannot identify the cause. Keep an issue record with the impact, action owner, next step and review date. Distinguish outputs, such as sessions held, from outcomes, such as whether participants obtained the intended support.

When a change is needed, state what will change, the expected effect, the resources and the safety implications. Check delegated limits before committing funds or altering scope. Define a review criterion that could show the change is not working. Learning requires a traceable adjustment, not silently redefining the target after results arrive. Use appropriate participant feedback with delivery information, and report uncertainty rather than promising that more activity necessarily creates better outcomes.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: the team has delivered more sessions but referral delays remain. It investigates the referral pathway and proposes a limited scheduling adjustment. The authorised manager approves a bounded trial with an owner and review date; the team tracks delays alongside session counts.

Decision points

Track an implementation issue with its impact, owner, action and review date; a list without follow-up is not a management response.

A variance from plan should be explained before action: compare intended and actual delivery, investigate causes and consider service effects.

Changes beyond delegated limits require approval; document why a change is proposed and its likely effects before committing resources.

Distinguish a delivery count from a result for participants; both can be useful but they answer different questions.

A learning adjustment should state the change, owner, expected effect and review criteria, while preserving safety and authorised scope.

Apply the lesson

Write an issue log entry and a change proposal for the outreach programme. Give one output measure and one outcome-oriented measure.

Check your reasoning

The entry explains impact and ownership. The proposal investigates causes, stays within authority and defines how service effects will be reviewed.

Assessment preparation

Explain the reasons behind each decision point. Practise with the worksheet using a different situation from the worked examples. The proposed assessment has 15 single-answer questions and a 70% pass threshold, requiring at least 11 correct whole-mark answers. Published settings and availability must be verified in the learning platform; this guide does not establish an assessment ID or certify completion.

Sources and evidence limits

[R3] Viscu, L.-I., and Marici, M. (2024). Challenges in supervising social workers. International Journal of Social and Educational Innovation, 11(22), 81-94. https://zenodo.org/records/14246369

Use in this course: The paper proposes a supervision framework attentive to work setting, professional training and organisational context. Limit: Conceptual guidance, not an effectiveness trial; it does not establish local licensing or scope-of-practice rules.

[S2] NASW and ASWB. Best Practice Standards in Social Work Supervision. https://www.socialworkers.org/Practice/NASW-Practice-Standards-Guidelines/Best-Practice-Standards-in-Social-Work-Supervision

Use in this course: Professional framework for supervision. Limit: Adapt to local roles, qualifications and regulatory requirements.

[S4] IFSW (2018). Global Social Work Statement of Ethical Principles. https://www.ifsw.org/global-social-work-statement-of-ethical-principles/

Use in this course: Dignity, participation, confidentiality and professional accountability. Limit: Does not replace applicable law or organisational safeguarding procedures.

The index record is a discovery aid, not a guarantee of quality. Read the source before applying its findings to a different setting. No article endorses this course.